

Hammer and TONGUES

Top government functionaries speaking in dissonant voices blunt India's campaign against Pakistan

| By Saurabh Shukla |

Even as India mounts pressure on Pakistan to bring the perpetrators of Mumbai to book, top UPA Government functionaries are busy scoring self goals that are seriously undermining the country's diplomatic efforts.

Last week, even as mandarins in South Block were telling their international interlocutors that Pakistan has not taken any credible action on the evidence provided on the Mumbai attacks, National Security Adviser (NSA) M.K. Narayanan said that Pakistan had reverted on the Mumbai attacks dossier, asking questions to which answers were being given. He also seemed satisfied by the action taken by Pakistan. In a stinging rebuke to the NSA, Pranab Mukherjee, the de facto number two in the Government and the External Affairs Minister, said, "We are awaiting official information."

While Narayanan seemed to go soft on Pakistan, Defence Minister A.K. Antony slammed it as the epicentre of global terrorism. Analysts believe that such statements may send wrong signals to the international community, especially when the heat is on Pakistan. "This would lead the international community to conclude that the Indian Government is a divided house," says G. Parthasarthy, former Indian envoy to Pakistan.

What is also hampering a decisive strategy against Pakistan is a tussle for supremacy amongst top ministers and South Block and North Block working at cross purposes. On January 30, when the Pakistan High Commissioner Shahid Malik met Home Minister P. Chidambaram, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) was clueless despite standing instructions from the prime minister that meetings with all foreign envoys have to be routed through the MEA. Sources say Chidambaram chose not to keep the MEA mandarins in the loop and the meeting was described as a courtesy call, even at this critical juncture when any action by the Government against Pakistan has to be well calibrated. Earlier when Chidambaram talked about ending trade links with Pakistan and reducing visas, he was contradicted by Mukherjee who, in turn, said that there was no such plan. Last month, when the home minister packed his bags for an official tour to the US, sources say South Block nixed the trip. Either there is a lack of coordination in the Government or no one seems to be in control.

If the UPA leadership does not act now, Pakistan which is working overtime to deflect the focus off the terror issue, would use the opportunity to get itself off the hook. ■

M.K. NARAYANAN,
National Security Adviser

"THE PAKISTAN GOVERNMENT HAS REVERTED TO US AND ASKED QUESTIONS ON THE MUMBAI DOSSIER."

"Pakistan is making an attempt to arrive at the truth. They are yet to receive a reply to the second set of queries."

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